THE 12 BEST *Happiness* BOOKS



NIKLAS GÖKE

Each year, a group of experts gathers to assess the global state of happiness. The result, ***the World Happiness Report***, is released on March 20, the International Day of Happiness.

This sounds like a positive thing, but, since 2005, overall happiness is decreasing while negative feelings like sadness and anger are on the rise. What's worse is the trend of more young people experiencing mental illness, addictions, and their consequences. To an extent, this is understandable.

It's tough to stay afloat mentally with everything going on in the world these days. No wonder we can crack at the slightest problem. But then we feel bad for not knowing how to handle it all and slip even deeper into unhappiness.

> **How do we stop this spiral?**
> **How can we actively combat our common enemy?**
> **What do we need to stop doing?**
> **And which habits will allow us to harness the power of happiness?**

Dozens of books can help educate ourselves about happiness from a multitude of perspectives. We can take the view of science, of history, of philosophy, mindfulness, and spirituality.

At **Four Minute Books**, we've hand-summarized over 800 books. In the course of doing so, we've learned a thing or two about happiness, and we recorded which experts and books have the most potential to add more joy to your life.

We've summarized over 800 books. These 12 will make you the happiest.

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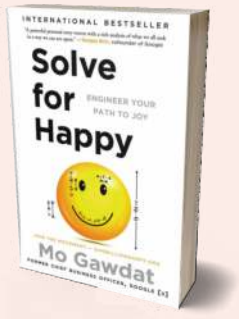
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01 SOLVE FOR HAPPY

by Mo Gawdat



FAVORITE QUOTE

"If you can afford the brain cycles to worry about the future, then by definition you have nothing to worry about right now. Right now, you're okay." — Mo Gawdat

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

Solve For Happy *lays out a former Google engineers formula for happiness, which shows you that it's our default state and how to overcome the obstacles we face in remaining in it.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

Sometimes, it takes a tragedy to understand happiness is a choice. Mo Gawdat knows. He lost his 21-year-old son Ali. He taught himself to choose happiness instead of sadness regardless. What made Gawdat's choice an obvious one was the formula that he and Ali had been working on for years: "***Happiness is equal to or greater than the events of your life minus your expectation of how life should be***."

This incredible book shows you why your perspective, more than anything else, determines your happiness.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. *Your inner voice is not the real you.*
2. *Many cognitive filters prevent you from seeing the whole world around you.*
3. *No matter if life is good or bad, staying in the present always makes you feel more content with it.*

If you want to learn more, you can read our free four-minute summary or get a copy for yourself.

READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

02 THE HAPPINESS PROJECT

by Gretchen Rubin



FAVORITE QUOTE

"The days are long, but the years are short." — Gretchen Rubin

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Happiness Project *will show you how to change your life without uprooting it, thanks to the findings of modern science, ancient history, and popular culture, which the author tested for a year.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

One day, Rubin realized she was working hard but not on what would matter to her at the end of her life. She hit pause and did happiness experiments for a year. The result is this amazing book full of practical advice on how to be happier at home, work, and in life. Follow her experiments, derive your own, test, improve, and take it step by step.

This is an extremely actionable, scientifically vetted book that everyone can learn from.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

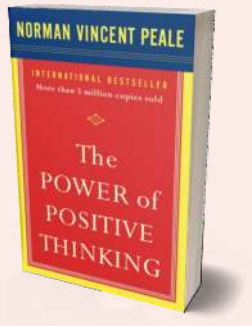
1. *Clean up your house and your brain, because all clutter wears us down.*
2. *Accept that you can only change yourself and that what you do every day matters most to build better relationships.*
3. *Money is like health — it doesn't guarantee you'll be happy but not having to worry about it makes your life a lot easier.*

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READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

03 THE POWER OF POSITIVE THINKING

by Norman Vincent Peale



FAVORITE QUOTE

"The way to happiness: Keep your heart free from hate, your mind from worry. Live simply, expect little, give much. Scatter sunshine, forget yourself, think of others. Try this for a week. You will be surprised." — Norman Vincent Peale

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Power Of Positive Thinking *will teach you how to believe in yourself, break the habit of worrying, and take control of your life by mastering your thoughts and changing your attitude.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

This book was on the New York Times bestsellers list for 186 weeks. For 48 of them, it held the top spot. It was translated into 40 languages and has sold five million copies. Peale uses affirmation and visualization to develop a positive mental attitude, practices which are just as sound today as they were in 1952, the book's original year of publication.

An "old but gold" read.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. *Start with confidence and watch your problems shrink.*
2. *Your world is nothing more than the thoughts you have about your experiences.*
3. *In order to live worry-free, first, imagine a worry-free life.*

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READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

04 THE SUBTLE ART OF NOT GIVING A F*CK

by Mark Manson



FAVORITE QUOTE

"The desire for more positive experience is itself a negative experience. And, paradoxically, the acceptance of one's negative experience is itself a positive experience."
— Mark Manson

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Subtle Art Of Not Giving A F*ck *does away with the positive psychology craze to instead give you a Stoic, no-BS approach to a life that might not always be happy but will always have meaning and be centered only around what's truly important to you.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

Mark Manson? The obnoxious blogger? Outrageous! A book with a curse word in the title on a list of books about happiness? Impossible! Yes, Mark Manson is here to polarize, but much more so, Mark Manson is here to help. If you hold off on your judgments long enough to digest what's behind the bright orange cover of this book, you'll be pleasantly surprised, probably even amazed. Mark provides a down-to-earth, positive, realistic but hopeful perspective on life.

He does so through his personal story, through colorful examples, and with a sense of humor that makes this one a breeze to get through – after which you'll no doubt feel uplifted.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

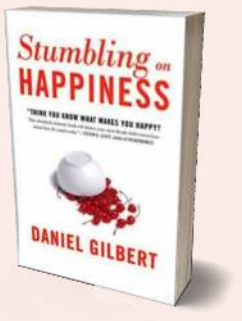
1. *Values you can't control are bad values to follow.*
2. *Don't believe you know anything with certainty because it'll keep you from improving.*
3. *Trying to leave a legacy might ruin your life.*

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READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

05 STUMBLING ON HAPPINESS

by Dan Gilbert



FAVORITE QUOTE

"The secret of happiness is variety, but the secret of variety, like the secret of all spices, is knowing when to use it." — Dan Gilbert

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

Stumbling On Happiness *examines the capacity of our brains to fill in gaps and simulate experiences, shows how our lack of awareness of these powers sometimes leads us to wrong decisions, and how we can change our behavior to synthesize our own happiness.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

This book examines how your brain tries to lie to you, specifically about what will happen in the future. Dan Gilbert's years of research show just how our minds trick us into worrying, which makes us unhappy with our decisions even before we make them.

It turns out that a big key to happiness is figuring out how to tell the difference between fact and fiction!

KEY TAKEAWAYS

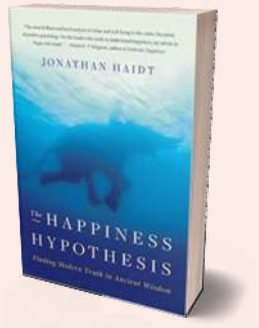
1. *Your brain is really bad at filling in the blanks, but it keeps on trying.*
2. *You should always compare products based on value, never based on price.*
3. *Bad experiences are better than no experiences.*

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READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

06 THE HAPPINESS HYPOTHESIS

by Jonathan Haidt



FAVORITE QUOTE

"Love and work are to people what water and sunshine are to plants." — Jonathan Haidt

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Happiness Hypothesis *is the most thorough analysis of how you can find happiness in our modern society, backed by plenty of scientific research, real-life examples, and even a literal formula for happiness.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

This book dives into the neurological aspects that contribute to happiness with a twist. Instead of getting lost in medical terms, Haidt employs the memorable analogy of a rider on an elephant. The metaphor shows how we can harness our brains to make us happy.

More importantly, you'll learn how to build thinking and relationship habits that will lead to long-term happiness.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. *Surround yourself with the people you love the most and live in accordance with reciprocity.*
2. *Do work that matters to you.*
3. *Find a partner who will stand by your side through sunshine and rain.*

If you want to learn more, you can read our free four-minute summary or get a copy for yourself.

READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

07 THE HAPPINESS ADVANTAGE

by Shawn Achor



FAVORITE QUOTE

"I could care less about whether it's half full or half empty — as long as I can fill it up." — Shawn Achor

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Happiness Advantage *turns the tables on happiness by proving it is a tool for success rather than of the result of it, sharing seven actionable principles you can use to increase both.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

Shawn Achor's research reveals the lies in the conventional idea that hard work and success lead to happiness. He's identified, with science, that happiness comes first, then you will become successful.

This book points to several ways that you can start being happier right now.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

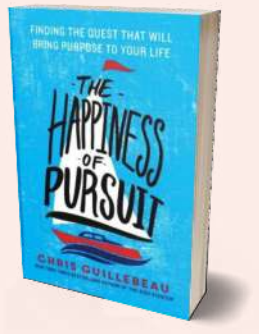
1. *Happiness comes before success, not after it.*
2. *You can train yourself to be optimistic with "The Tetris Effect."*
3. *Fall up instead of down.*

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READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

08 THE HAPPINESS OF PURSUIT

by Chris Guillebeau



FAVORITE QUOTE

"It's your life, so why not be intentional about it?" — Chris Guillebeau

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Happiness Of Pursuit *is a call to take control of your life by going on a quest which will fill your life with meaning, purpose, and a whole lot of adventure.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

Chris Guillebeau wrote this book after visiting every country in the world. Can you imagine how much you'd learn on such a journey? Guillebeau made note of the people he met that were on a mission of their own.

After his return, he wrote this book to help you find yours and become happier by doing so.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

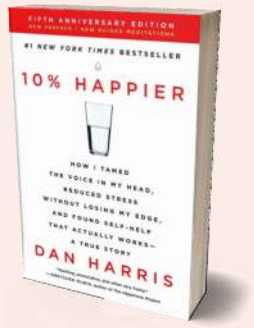
1. *When the world calls out to you, listen.*
2. *Adjust your life to accommodate your quest.*
3. *Your quest will give you purpose because it is a reward in and of itself.*

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READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

09 10% HAPPIER

by Dan Harris



FAVORITE QUOTE

"There's no point in being unhappy about things you can't change and no point being unhappy about things you can." — Dan Harris

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

10% Happier *gives skeptics an easy "in" to meditation by taking a very non-fluffy approach to the science behind this mindfulness practice and showing you how and why letting go of your ego is important to living a stress-free life.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

Former ABC News correspondent Dan Harris snapped under the pressure of his job. After having a panic attack on live television, he looked into what was really important.

The Westerner thoroughly investigated mindfulness and then reported on useful ways even skeptics can embrace it to be happier.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

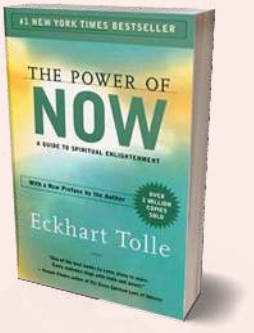
1. *The problem with your ego is that it's never satisfied.*
2. *Be simple, not a simpleton – letting go of your ego won't make you a pushover.*
3. *Meditation increases your mindfulness and compassion by giving you a fourth habitual response: non-judgment.*

If you want to learn more, you can read our free four-minute summary or get a copy for yourself.

READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

10 THE POWER OF NOW

by Eckhart Tolle



FAVORITE QUOTE

"Realize deeply that the present moment is all you have. Make the NOW the primary focus of your life." — Eckhart Tolle

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Power of Now *shows you that every minute you spend worrying about the future or regretting the past is a minute lost because we can only live in the present and act in every moment as it occurs.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

One late night, Tolle had deeply depressing thoughts, wondering what made his life so difficult. In a lightbulb moment, he realized the answer was in his "I" — the picture of himself that his brain had created. When he woke up the next day, he felt reborn. He'd finally let go.

His advice on how to better focus on the present is contained in this multi-million-copy bestseller.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

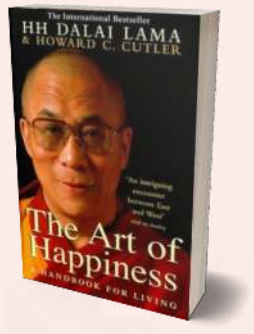
1. *Life is just a series of present moments.*
2. *All pain is a result of resistance to the things you cannot change.*
3. *You can free yourself from pain by constantly observing your mind and not judging your thoughts.*

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READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

11 THE ART OF HAPPINESS

by HH Dalai Lama



FAVORITE QUOTE

"My religion is very simple. My religion is kindness." — Dalai Lama

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Art Of Happiness *is the result of a psychiatrist interviewing the Dalai Lama on how he personally achieved inner peace, calmness, and happiness.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

According to one of the world's most celebrated leaders, the Dalai Lama, happiness comes from training our minds and hearts to respond appropriately to the experiences we have.

This book is the kind of message that anyone can learn from, religious or not.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. *You don't have to be religious to be spiritual.*
2. *The only constant thing is change.*
3. *Know your limits.*

If you want to learn more, you can read our free four-minute summary or get a copy for yourself.

READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

12 THE LIFE-CHANGING MAGIC OF TIDYING UP

by Marie Kondo



FAVORITE QUOTE

"The question of what you want to own is actually the question of how you want to live your life." — Marie Kondo

THE BOOK IN ONE SENTENCE

The Life-Changing Magic Of Tidying Up *takes you through the process of simplifying, organizing, and storing your belongings step by step to make your home a place of peace and clarity.*

WHY SHOULD YOU READ IT?

Konmari's mega-bestseller has sold over six million copies world-wide and led to her own TV show. The power of behind this global phenomenon lies in the simplicity of its mantra: "Does this spark joy?"

According to Marie Kondo, this single question can greatly improve our lives and homes.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. *Move from easy to hard items when considering what to keep.*
2. *YODO – you only declutter once (if you do it right).*
3. *Ask yourself a few simple questions, like "Does this spark joy?" for each item you consider throwing away.*

If you want to learn more, you can read our free four-minute summary or get a copy for yourself.

READ ON FOUR MINUTE BOOKS

Conclusion

We've summarized over 800 books to date, many of them about happiness. In our opinion, these are the best happiness books to read this year.

Let go of material possessions, focus on the people around you, *learn the science of happiness, and practice some of the tips from these books. In finding out which ones work for you and which ones don't, you'll be well on your way to a happier life.*

Don't wait. Happiness is an urgent matter. *Start reading some of the best books on happiness today!*

